Juvenile Materials

H 1690

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A. Background

This instruction sheet presents guidelines on the assignment of Library of Congress subject headings to juvenile materials. These instructions do not apply to the assignment of Children's and Young Adults' Subject Headings (CYAC; formerly called AC headings).

For guidelines on the assignment of classification numbers to juvenile materials, see F 615 of the Library of Congress *Classification and Shelflisting Manual* (CSM).

LC practice: As stated in H 1075, LC catalogers will no longer use form subdivisions. Instead assign an appropriate term or terms from the Library of Congress Genre/Form Terms (LCGFT), e.g. ***Fiction***, ***Children's audiobooks*, *Picture books***, etc. To replace a form subdivision that includes a demographic group, also assign Library of Congress Demographic Group Terms (LCDGT) to bring out the audience of the resource being cataloged, e.g. ***Children***, ***Middle school students***, ***Teenagers***, etc..

B. Recent revisions

2026-01: Updated template. Adjusted age range for juvenile topical materials. Added instructions related to use of LCDGT. Added instructions related to LCGFT implementation.

C. Determining whether a work is juvenile

For the purposes of subject heading assignment, treat topical materials intended primarily for children and young people through the age of 12, or the 7th grade, as juvenile. Treat *belles lettres* -- such as fiction, poetry, etc. -- intended primarily for children and young people through the age of 12, or the 7th grade, as juvenile.

If explicit information on age level (e.g., "pre-school through age 12," "ages 8-12," etc.) has been provided by the publisher on the dust jacket, cover, front matter, CIP data sheet, etc., use this as the basis for determining that the work is intended to be juvenile. If the age level is not explicitly stated, determine the intent by a careful examination of the preface, text, series statement, etc. In more difficult cases, use such indications as format, publisher, treatment of previous works in the same series, etc., as clues to the intended audience of the work. If in doubt, assign adult headings and subdivisions.

D. Topical juvenile materials

Assign LC subject headings and subdivisions to topical materials for juveniles up through age 12 or 7th grade. Use the form subdivisions ***–Juvenile literature***, ***–Juvenile films***, ***–Juvenile sound recordings***, and ***–Juvenile software*** as the final element in all subject headings assigned to topical juvenile materials unless special form headings or subdivisions have been established, for example, ***Children's encyclopedias and dictionaries*; *–Dictionaries, Juvenile***; ***–Encyclopedias, Juvenile***; ***–Juvenile humor***. With rare exceptions, if a work is assigned any juvenile heading, all headings assigned must reflect the juvenile nature of the work.

LC practice: Do not use the form subdivisions ***--Juvenile literature***, ***--Dictionaries, Juvenile***, etc. Instead assign an appropriate term or terms from LCGFT, e.g. ***Picture books***, ***Dictionaries***, etc. To replace a form subdivision that includes a demographic group, also assign LCDGT to bring out the audience of the resource being cataloged, e.g. ***Children***.

E. Textbooks

For guidelines on the assignment of subject headings to textbooks and works about textbooks, see H 2187.

F. Juvenile belles lettres

F.1. Definitions

Belles lettres: Literature that is an end in itself and is not practical or purely informative. The term may refer to poetry, fiction, drama, literary essays, etc.

F.2. General rule

Assign juvenile form headings and subdivisions to *belles lettres* for juveniles up through age 12 or 7th grade, for example, ***Children's stories***; ***Nursery rhymes***; ***–Juvenile drama***; ***–Juvenile fiction***; ***–Juvenile poetry***.

Where juvenile form headings do not exist and are not deemed appropriate to establish, assign adult headings, for example, ***Ghost stories***; ***Detective and mystery stories***. Do not further subdivide these adult form headings by the juvenile form subdivisions ***–Juvenile drama***, ***–Juvenile fiction***, or ***–Juvenile poetry***.

LC practice: Do not use the form subdivisions ***--Juvenile drama***, ***--Juvenile fiction***, and ***--Juvenile poetry***. Instead assign an appropriate term or terms from LCGFT, e.g. ***Drama***, ***Fiction***, ***Poetry***. To replace a form subdivision that includes a demographic group, also assign LCDGT to bring out the audience of the resource being cataloged, e.g. ***Children***.

Example:

Title: Sardines swim high across the sky and other poems

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650 #0 $a Imaginary creatures $v Juvenile poetry.
650 #0 $a Children’s poetry, American.
```

LC practice:

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650 #0 $a Imaginary creatures.
650 #0 $a Children’s poetry, American.
655 #7 $a Poetry. $2 lcgft
655 #7 $a Picture books. $2 lcgft
385 ## $a Children $2 lcdgt
```

F.3. Exceptions

***Belles lettres* for young adults**

Do not assign juvenile form headings or subdivisions to *belles lettres* for young adults.

The form subdivision *--Juvenile literature*

Do not use the form subdivision ***--Juvenile literature*** under form headings for juvenile *belles lettres*. The exceptions to this practice that occurred in the past, for example, ***Limericks--Juvenile literature***; ***Riddles--Juvenile literature***, have been removed from the subject authority file and should not be used or reestablished.

Folklore

Do not treat folklore materials as *belles lettres*. Do not use juvenile form subdivisions under headings for specific folklore genres, such as ***Tales***, ***Fairy tales***, ***Folk literature***, etc., nor under the subdivision ***--Folklore***. For guidelines on the assignment of subject headings to folklore materials, see H 1627.

G. Polyglot books

Establish and assign to both individual works and to collections of juvenile fiction, drama, and poetry presented in three or more languages headings of the type ***Children's stories, Polyglot***; ***Children's plays, Polyglot***; ***Children's poetry, Polyglot***.

H. Juvenile software

Assign headings of the type ***[*topic*]--Juvenile software*** for materials coded for intellectual level **a**, **b**, or **c** in MARC field 008/22 (Target audience). Also assign headings of this type for materials coded **f** (Specialized) if there is evidence that the material is juvenile in nature. For guidelines on the assignment of subject headings to software, see H 2070.

LC practice: Do not use the form subdivision ***--Juvenile software***. Instead assign an appropriate term or terms from LCGFT, e.g. ***Software***. To replace a form subdivision that includes a demographic group, also assign LCDGT to bring out the audience of the resource being cataloged, e.g. ***Children***.

I. Bibliographies of juvenile materials on specific topics

Assign headings of the type ***[*topic*]--Juvenile literature--Bibliography***. For lists of juvenile audiovisual materials, assign headings of the type ***[*topic*]--Juvenile films--Catalogs*** or ***[*topic*]--Juvenile sound recordings--Discography***.

LC practice: Do not use the form subdivisions of the type ***--Juvenile films***, ***--Bibliography***, etc. Instead assign an appropriate term or terms from LCGFT, e.g. ***Children's films***, ***Bibliographies***, etc. To replace a form subdivision that includes a demographic group, also assign LCDGT to bring out the audience of the resource being cataloged, e.g. ***Children***.

Revision history

2026-01: Updated template. Adjusted age range for juvenile topical materials. Added instructions related to use of LCDGT. Added instructions related to LCGFT implementation.